Meanwhile, the police have also registered a case against VPC convenor Fr Theodacious D'Cruz, whose comments against minister for sports and Haj pilgrimage V. Abdurahiman ("There is a terrorist called Abdurahiman") had gone viral. Not only did the church have to take flak for it, it also drove a communal wedge in the coastal areas, stripping the protest of its moral edge. The minister had called those opposing the port at Vizhinjam traitors out to block the development of the state. On November 30, both the church and Fr D'Cruz apologised for the remarks, terming it a slip of the tongue, but the damage was done by then.

Sensing the tide had turned, church leaders tried to negotiate a truce, with Cardinal Baselios Mar Cleemis, head of the Malankara Catholic Church, acting as mediator. They met chief secretary V.P. Joy on December 3 in the first round of negotiations with the government. Later, Cleemis met the CM to brief him, but was reportedly told that violence or attempts to stall the construction work in Vizhinjam would not be tolerated. Even if he won this round, Pinarayi is aware Vizhinjam could still turn out to be political dynamite. There have been government lapses too, especially an overconfidence that it could win over the community, not to speak of the intelligence deficit on the possibility of the protests turning violent.

The Latin Catholic church fanned the flames but now looks like it overplayed its hand. The church has also failed to explain its change in stand over the port since 2015 when its then archbishop had welcomed the project. The church's deep connections with the local fishing industry in Vizhinjam have also played a part in the protests, say old-timers here. When the port becomes operational, the fishing industry's landing and auction centres from Varkala to Vizhinjam will have to change location and perhaps move out of the church's ambit. According to one veteran, this is a major cause of worry as it will seriously hit the church's revenues. As in most such matters, a lot of it boils down to the money—that sea of no erosion. ■



Photographs by ANI

UTTAR PRADESH

YOGI'S BIG GAME PLAN

By Prashant Srivastava

The Uttar Pradesh government wants to lift its game beyond its ubiquitous wrestling akharas. India's most populous state—a laggard in sports infrastructure—has put a new scheme in place that aims to change that. Called One District One Sport (ODOS), it seeks to promote a sports culture at the ground level in all its 75 districts.

On December 2, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath launched the ODOS programme under which each district has got a game to foster. Talents will be identified and their skills honed to enable them to perform at all levels—from district to state, national and, ultimately, international tournaments and championships. The government has earmarked Rs 8.55 crore for sports in this financial year.

According to the sports department, more than one district can patronise the same sport. It depends on the tradition, talent, infrastructure and demand among the players there. For example, wrestling is identified as a district sport for Baghpat as well as Gorakhpur. Similarly, Bareilly and Lucknow will get to hone hockey. Fifty players have been engaged as coaches on a monthly honorarium of Rs 1.50 lakh to prepare players to go right up to the world stage.

In another micro-level scheme, the state is planning to build a new stadium in every district under the One District One Stadium (ODOS) programme. The beginning has been made. Four new stadiums are set to be operational in Sambhal, Chandauli, Hapur and Shamli districts soon. Navneet Sehgal, additional chief secretary (sports), who is spearheading the project, told INDIA TODAY: "We will try to identify both rural and urban talent and provide them proper training and logistics so that the level of their game improves. On the other hand, for ODOS, we are focusing on sports infrastructure mainly in the smaller towns. We want to make UP's sports talent ready for inter-state, national and international events."

For former Olympian hockey player Syed Ali, the initiatives seem good as of now. "Players in sports other than cricket and tennis struggle for infrastructure and logistics. We need permanent coaches in smaller towns to train them. We need physios to guide them in fitness awareness. If this concept works at the hyperlocal level, it could be a game-changer."

A sports department official says it is for the first time in years that sports has been made a priority by any government in the state. UP's first sports university, named after Major Dhyan Chand, is coming up in Meerut. And Yogi is keeping an eye on things like a coach would on a new ward. He has instructed MLAs and MPs to promote competitions at the village level. Training in 16 types of sports is being imparted through three sports colleges and 44 sports hostels, he said in a statement.

INDIA PICTURE



THE ONE DISTRICT ONE SPORT SCHEME AIMS TO PROMOTE A SPORTS CULTURE FROM THE GRASSROOTS LEVEL

A string of smaller outlays speaks of serious intent as of now: monthly allowances for players in national championships being hiked from Rs 1,000 to Rs 2,500; diet money for players being increased from Rs 250 to Rs 375 per day; the Eklavya Sports Fund being set up to help needy players. The proof of the pudding will be in the eating, of course. Here, that will mean not a lone Dhyan Chand rising out of Prayagraj due to sheer talent, but the sense of a solid support system serving aces across sports. ■